

The GCC Transition Playbook Nobody Writes

Lessons from the receiving end

I'm not writing this as someone who has finished learning. I'm writing it while actively preparing for transition leadership roles, and sharing it because I suspect I'm not the only one who needed a playbook like this.

Almost everything is written from the wrong side of the handover

2,117

GCCs now operating in India

\$98.4B

combined market value

74%

of corporate transformations fail to create lasting value (BCG)

Nearly all of that guidance is written by the person who designs and executes the handover, not the person who receives it and has to make it work afterward.

01

The plan and the reality are two different documents

The transition plan tells you what was supposed to happen. It rarely tells you what actually did, or why shortcuts were taken under deadline pressure. Your first job is finding that gap, not executing the plan as written.

02

“Complete” and “stable” are measured months apart

Cutover gets celebrated, but it isn't the finish line, it's closer to the starting gun. Missing data, unclear decision ownership, and processes that only worked on paper surface after the handover is declared done.

03

A team built to survive handover isn't built to grow

A team assembled to absorb a transition is optimized for continuity, not scale. Inherit it as-is and you inherit its limits too. Growth and stabilization are different disciplines, and they shouldn't be run as if they're the same one.

04

The skills that designed it aren't the skills it needs next

The outgoing transition lead is usually excellent at compliance and risk mitigation. What the team needs six months later is different: judgment under ambiguity and the presence to rebuild trust, not a copy of the old playbook.

05

Documentation tells you what, almost never why

The why is what lets you make good calls on everything the documentation never anticipated. Extract it directly from the outgoing team while they're still reachable, because it leaves with them once the TSA expires.

06

The wrong metric at the wrong time blocks growth

Ramp-up rate and setup cost matter in month one. Still leading with them eighteen months later means optimizing for a phase that already ended. Roughly half of India's GCCs have climbed to outcome-based “Portfolio Hub” maturity, and the metric shift is a real part of how.

If you're about to inherit a transition

- Get direct access to the outgoing team before the TSA expires, ask “why,” not just “what”
- Separately assess what's documented as complete vs. what's actually stable
- Audit the team you're inheriting for what it was built to do, and what it wasn't
- Delay a metrics overhaul until stable, but set a deliberate date to make the shift
- Identify who has real decision authority vs. who's stuck routing through HQ approval
- Build your own record as you go. The next person to receive a handover will need it

Twice, about a decade apart, I was the one who received the handover.

Not the person who designed either transition. The person who inherited what got handed over and had to keep it standing, then growing.

If you've lived through a receiving-end handover and noticed the same gap, I'd like to hear what you'd add.

[Full article on the blog](#)